

PUPPP/PEP skin rash

» What, when, and how often?

Pruritic urticarial papules and plaques of pregnancy (PUPPP) and polymorphic eruption of pregnancy (PEP)—is an itchy skin rash that usually appears on the abdomen (other than on the belly button) and then spreads to other parts of the body. It looks a bit like eczema, characterized by small, fluid-filled blisters. It's a condition of late pregnancy—usually occurring from around 35 weeks pregnant, but it occurs in fewer than half a percent of all pregnancies.

» What causes it?

No one is sure what causes PUPPP, but it is most common in women carrying boys (interestingly, a study found male DNA in skin biopsies of PUPPP rash) or multiples and in first pregnancies. It rarely occurs during second or subsequent pregnancies. Some people think it may be hereditary.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

The most significant effect is itchiness, usually worst in the first few days of the condition. It doesn't seem to have any effect on the unborn baby, though as a precaution many doctors recommend that the baby is induced at 39 weeks.

» What can I do?

Keep cool by wearing loose-fitting cotton clothing. You can talk to your doctor about topical treatments. The rash disappears of its own accord within a week of having the baby. In rare cases it may linger for a bit longer.

Heat rash

» What, when, and how often?

Also known as prickly heat, a heat rash is a raised red, itchy rash that affects parts of the skin where heat builds up—folds in the neck and abdomen, for example.

» What causes it?

During pregnancy you will probably feel hotter and sweatier than usual, which can cause a rash to develop where the air can't easily dry away the sweat.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Nothing at all other than feeling irritated by your prickly skin. The rash is completely benign and has no side effects.

» What can I do?

Keep as cool as possible and wear loose-fitting cotton clothing. Cool and soothe your skin using a washcloth that has been soaked in cold water. Avoid highly scented soaps.

Clogged milk ducts

» What, when, and how often?

Many women don't realize that milk production begins during pregnancy. Part of this process means that the milk ducts in your breasts stretch and enlarge to accommodate the increase in fluid. Sometimes, in the second half of your

pregnancy, the ducts can get clogged up, making your breasts feel lumpy and tender. The lumps may even look red compared with the rest of the skin on your breast.

» What causes it?

Your breasts are busy making milk, but until your baby is born, you don't have an outlet for it. The backup of milk can cause blockages in the ducts.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

A blocked duct is really a good sign that your body is making milk. It's really nothing to worry about, other than that it can cause some discomfort and tenderness. Note that if the lump isn't red or painful, it would be worth mentioning it to your doctor, just in case it's a breast lump that is unrelated to your milk production.

» What can I do?

A cool washcloth placed over the affected area on your breast can help to ease tenderness. Gently use your thumbs and fingers to massage around the blocked duct with the goal of freeing up the blockage. You may have some discharge from your nipple as you do this—that's fine.

Leaking milk

» What, when, and how often?

This can occur at any time from your second trimester, but is most likely to occur at the end of your pregnancy as your breasts become full. Usually you will leak colostrum rather than actual milk. Colostrum is a yellowish, thick secretion. It's more digestible and richer in nutrients than breast milk.

» What causes it?

Very simply, your breasts fill with milk but until the baby is born, there's no outlet for all the liquid. The result is that some of it gets squeezed out unintentionally from your breasts.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Your body is gearing up to feed your baby once he is born. There is no relationship between leaky breasts and ability (or inability) to produce enough milk to nurse a baby.

» What can I do?

Use breast pads to soak up any fluid from your nipples. Change them regularly if you need to.

Bleeding

» What, when, and how often?

One third of pregnant women will experience some form of spotting or bleeding in their first trimester. It can be brown, pink, or bright red. Sometimes large blood clots are expelled. Bleeding or spotting can happen later on in pregnancy, too.

» What causes it?

In early pregnancy the increased levels of hormones make the surface of the cervix fragile and prone to spotting or bleeding. Later your cervix is softer and has increased blood flow to it. As a result it can bleed or become bruised.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

While worrying, bleeding is common in the first trimester. It doesn't necessarily mean you have miscarried, though it should always be checked. Bleeding later in pregnancy should always be checked too, as it could be a sign of a low-lying placenta, placental abruption, or preterm labor.

» What can I do?

Speak to your doctor as soon as possible. You will probably be offered an ultrasound scan to put your mind at ease and check that nothing is wrong. Report any heavy bleeding immediately, especially if it is accompanied by any pain.

Protruding navel

» What, when, and how often?

During the third trimester of pregnancy, your abdomen will be heading toward full stretch and one of the results is that your belly button may appear to "pop out." This usually occurs after the 24th week of pregnancy and happens to almost all pregnant women.

» What causes it?

The simple matter of a growing abdomen (growing baby and growing uterus) is the cause of your popped-out belly button.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

A protruding navel is not the sign of anything sinister going on and its only effect is that it might look like a very low third nipple if you're wearing tight-fitting clothes.

» What can I do?

Absolutely nothing. Your belly button will stop protruding and sit neatly back in its original position as soon as you've had your baby.



Standing proud If you are happy with your changing body, then show off your belly.